Community Gardens in Small Cities

A short field report, 2025 season

Community gardens have become a common sight in small cities over the last decade. They turn empty lots into shared spaces where neighbors grow vegetables, herbs and flowers. This report looks at 12 gardens and describes what made them succeed.

Most gardens started with a small group of volunteers and a loan of land from the city. In the first year, the average garden had 18 plots and a waiting list of about 9 families. By the third year, the number of plots had nearly doubled.

1. What the gardeners told us

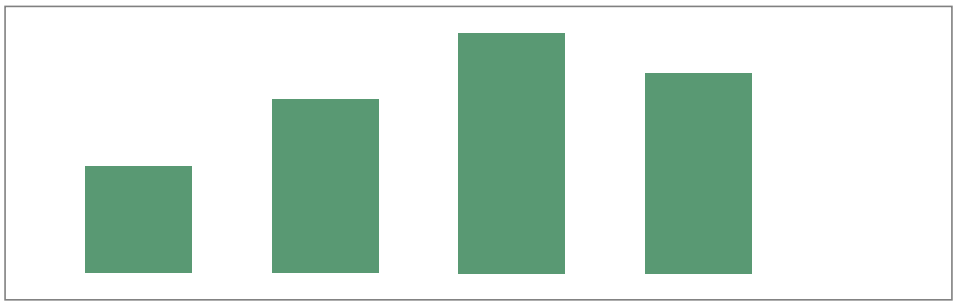
We asked gardeners why they joined and what kept them coming back. The most frequent answer was the chance to meet people from the same street. Fresh food came second, and many people said that working outside helped them relax after work.

Water was the biggest practical problem. Gardens that installed rain barrels early used 40% less city water during the summer. Shared tools were the second problem, because they were often lost or left out in the rain.

> **Key numbers**
> 12 gardens visited. 214 active gardeners. Average plot size: 6.5 square meters. Typical yearly fee: 15 dollars.

Small cities have one clear advantage. Land is cheaper, and local officials are often easy to reach. Several gardens received permission within a few weeks.

The main risk is that a garden depends on a few people. When a leader moves away, activity can drop quickly. Rotating roles every season helps to avoid this.



In short, a garden needs land, water and a group of people who share the work. With these three things in place, even a small lot can feed many families and bring a street together.